

Michael Browne

Of all the technologies that evolve every year, one of the last products you'd expect to see any changes in are good old inkjet printers. We've seen breakthroughs in processor technology, the world of graphics has had its share of innovations as well... the list is too long to mention here! So like CRT monitors, you'd probably expect inkjet

printing as a technology to stagnate as well... right? After all, what could change? Definitely not the number of colours used. Nor the number of ink tanks.

Surprise! Inkjet printing as a technology has evolved, even over the past year, since our last test. While these changes may not be pathbreaking, there are constant advances being made in printing technologies as a whole—whether they are advances in dyes and

pigments used in inks, or print-head technology. Seeing is believing, and last year's test prints compared to this year's batch reveal everything.

Our contestants came from four major players—HP sent us three printers, Epson sent two, three Canons made it for the test race and a lone Lexmark arrived too. Nine devices to bring colour to your pages, and we're spotlighting each of them.

Canon Pixma iP1700

Look at my pix, ma!

The iP1700 was the smallest offering from Canon in our labs. It is built reasonably well, but at Rs 3,995, it seems built to a price. Apart from the classy looking badging on the front, there's nothing much to write about its looks. The iP1700 misses an output tray, so make sure your printer is placed away from the edge of the table, unless you want to decorate your floor with printouts.

The power adapter is visible underneath the printer, tucked away in a recess. The top is pretty bare, with just two buttons—one for power, and the other to resume printing.

Canon's printer settings interface is good. In fact, most of the settings are not hidden. The iP1700 is reasonably speedy, but demanding tasks will see it lag-

ging—expected, really, considering it's a very entry-level offering. Our text document fared well, though we did notice aliasing even at higher settings. The fonts were readable at all sizes though—no serious issues there.

As soon as our combination document was printed, we immediately noticed the lack of detail in the embedded photograph. Highlighting on the fruit was decent, colour saturation was at par with the similarly-priced D2360 from HP. Text readability was better, and the reverse text test was a complete success at both economy and extravagant settings.

Bearing the Pixma badge



should translate to at least decent photo printing; however, Canon makes no bones about declaring the iP1700 a value offering. We were surprised to see the little Pixma bringing up some very acceptable results. Though it took its time (over three and a half minutes), our test photograph came out well, exactly the way it should be. Of course, the HP D4168 and the Canon iP5300, not to mention the R390, all get the job done better, but at under Rs 4,000, the iP1700 makes a strong point for itself. The only shortcoming is, it probably won't be as suited to portrait printing because it had issues with skin tones and texturing.

For Rs 3,995, Canon's iP1700 is a good printer for basic, everyday use with the occasional photo print thrown in. For a little more, though, you can get the D4168, which is a better all-round performer.

Canon Pixma iP3300

The middleman

Canon's iP3300 immediately strikes you as a big printer. That quality feel to the plastic material is present right down to the quality of movable trays and flaps. Although we've definitely seen better build quality from Canon, the iP3300 is much better built than the iP1700. It cashes in on a pleasing light-grey / dark-grey finish, and the rounded corners will appeal to the aesthetic senses. There are two buttons on the front—a resume-print button and the mandatory power button, a cool transparent one that fits flush with the front panel. There's PictBridge support inbuilt as well.

The iP3300 is positioned as an intermediate product, bridging the gap between regular inkjet printers and the much costlier

photo inkjets. It's got a four-tank individual colour ink system.

The iP3300 makes for a good text printer, but its four individual tanks may seem a bit much for such a task. There was slight visible aliasing around text edges, but well within acceptable levels. This printer performed just behind its bigger brother (iP5300) and HP's D4168.

Printing PDFs and other such documents, and combining text with colour images, is very possible on the iP3300 without sacrificing on details. One area the iP3300 missed out on in our combination document test was the highlighting on the fruit. Though



not as bad as the Epson printers, it peerformed a bit behind the D4168, with decent results. The photograph also lacked some detail, but wasn't downright unacceptable. From experience, Canon's forte as far as printers go is contrast. In typical fashion, the iP3300 did very well in the reverse text test, and provided a clear view even with tiny font sizes.

Photo printing isn't something the iP3300 is built to tackle. However, the iP3300 manages to perform well here, with good reproduction of finer details like texturing on the leather and the hair in the portraits. Where it misses out a bit on is the actual portrait part of the test photograph: skin tones were slightly off, the colour a little too warm. We'd estimate it was 15 per cent short of the quality of its excellent sibling, the iP5300, but it's priced lower, at Rs 6,495. You decide if this disparity is too much.